

better contrast. These do not require a backlight to function and can be made very thin, flexible or transparent. They can even be printed on flexible surfaces.

Also, OLEDs are very durable and operate over a broader temperature range. These are expected to be more efficiently manufactured than LCDs and plasma displays.

Why did you choose to work on OLEDs and not on LCDs and plasmas? Is this R&D on OLED technology meant for TV sets or other applications?

We do have an R&D division in Ghaziabad which is working on developing plasma technology. It was a business decision based upon several factors to go in for plasmas and not LCDs. We chose to work on OLEDs as these represent the future of technology. Currently, the prototype of small-size OLED screen for use in mobile phones has been prepared, and research is on for larger sizes which can be used for TV sets or other applications.

Do you plan to work on LCD and plasma TV technologies as well some time in future?

As mentioned earlier, we have a plasma display panel research centre at Ghaziabad. Currently, the plans to go into production have not been crystallised, but the final decision on this will be taken sometime into the future.

What kind of future do you see in the OLED segment considering the big players like Sony and Samsung are reining the market?

Sony and Samsung are the key players focusing on OLED technology, with Sony trying to capture the OLED TV market and Samsung developing the technology for mobile phones. Samtel is already a market leader in the manufacturing of CPTs and display systems and looks at the OLED segment as a key area of growth.

The OLED industry has been registering high growth since 2007, with contribution mostly from the active-matrix (AMOLED) market. The increasing need for exceptional picture quality and feel is known to be the major factor for the imminent growth of OLEDs.

The global market for OLED displays is projected to exceed \$4.5 billion by 2010, while in India the forecast for AMOLED TV market in 2008 is 13,000 units. Samtel is poised to capitalise on this growing demand for OLED displays. The small-size prototype is ready at our research centre at IIT Kanpur, and we are now working on larger sizes.

How has been your foray in the defence industry so far?

The foray has been very successful, especially in terms of establishing Samtel in the avionics display segment. Our joint ventures with Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) and Thales have brought in international expertise and knowledge into the domain. This has played a major role in giving us a firm foothold in the indigenous avionics product segment, and recognition in the international market.

Through a collaborative relationship with DRDO lab, Samtel has developed multifunctional displays, which have recently undergone successful flight trials on Su-30 aircrafts. The future looks especially promising as far as this segment is concerned.

What are your product offerings to the defence industry?

Samtel Display Systems (SDS) is a key player in the international market in manufacturing of high-technology equipment for avionics, military and professional applications. Its products include helmet-mounted displays, head-up displays, head-down displays, multi-function displays as well as thermal imaging and control displays for armoured military vehicles and displays for other professional applications.

Samtel has also developed colour CRT- and AMLCD-based multifunctional displays for avionics, for its customers worldwide. Our services include the design, development, manufacture, testing and qualification of products to meet customers' specifications.

Where do you see yourself in the industry in the next couple of years?

Samtel has already established itself in the CPT segment. We now look forward towards consolidating our position in the Indian market. Our avionics division has already taken off and succeeded in developing strong business relationships. Besides this, our nouveau forays in industrial automation and special-purpose machines sector, as also in knowledge process outsourcing are now gaining ground.

What is next from Samtel?

In the CPT segment, we are ready to launch 53cm true-flat picture tubes during the last quarter of FY 2008-09. It should help us cater to customer demands for this particular market. In avionics, we plan to move up the value chain from displays to avionic systems, thus expanding our bandwidth in this industry. ●

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